sian populations. Four of these regions will soon "join" Russia after the September 23 referendum, and become Russian territory. The referendum is an inflection point in the war. Russian President Vladimir Putin's announcement calling for a partial mobilisation of his country's military reservists also signalled Moscow's resolve to pursue its objectives in Ukraine.

It is never too late, and indeed vital, for channels of communication to be maintained and for the sides to go back to where they were in 2014—the negotiating table. Let's not forget that the shadow-boxing between the West and Russia over Ukraine and other post-Soviet spaces has been brewing for years. To pretend, and there is no other word, that the war began only on February 24 is as big a deception as the claim of Saddam Hussein possessing weapons of mass destruction. A different kind of war was being waged since 2013. The western narrative on who started the war, who is winning it and consternation over the trampling of all canons of international law by Russia is uniform and countenances no dissent. Despite the television images, it is still a low-intensity war on both sides, with the full military power of Russia not yet in deployment. NATO is not deployed too, except through proxy means.

The only way to prevent the conflict from escalating and ending it is if all sides spend their formidable energies in finding a diplomatic solution. In the shrillness of the rhetoric, what is forgotten is that such a solution exists. It involves taking into account the legitimate security interests of all sides, unless the calculation is that Russia has been trapped and can and should be brought to its knees. This translates into dismemberment or a regime change in Moscow, in the belief that one or both of these outcomes will finally create the conditions for peaceful coexistence in Europe for all times to come. A trapped Russia is, however, a dangerous Russia.

Ukraine has become the Syria of Europe. It will take years to recover from the influx of weapons, the mercenaries, the refugees, and debilitation of its economy and polity. Someone will have to pay for its reconstruction. Undoubtedly, Europe has been reunited in the face of aggression, but as the conflict continues, it faces growing differences on how to proceed further. It is caught between the hardliners who do not want any compromise with Russia and the pragmatists. Election results in Italy reflect the mood of a large segment of Europe. Europe is in search of a leader who can extricate the continent from this morass.

Russia, too, is hurting. It will hurt more in coming years as the sanctions and its isolation from the western financial, trade, investment and technology world begin to take effect. While sanctions have typically not brought nations to heel and Russia is no Iran or Myanmar, the fact is that the sanctions are superimposed on an economy that has not seen any worthwhile structural reform in the past few decades. Much more importantly, Europe, more than the US, has to find a way to live side by side with Russia, and vice versa. Western homilies to India during tense moments when Pakistan crossed Indian red lines readily come to mind.

The disruption of energy supplies to Europe and elsewhere and of food and commodities to the developing world are creating inflationary and recessionary pressures globally. The prognosis for the European economy for the next few years is bleak. The US is battling inflationary trends. There is pressure on the Indian rupee, but other more vulnerable economies face much bigger dangers. Africa and even China are facing headwinds.

So, what does this mean for India? We should be both steadfast and persuasive in our call for a return to dialogue and diplomacy. We should not fan the flames of war. We must also not lose sight of the interests we have and the challenges we face even as we are propositioned by all sides.



POINT NOT TAKEN?
PM Modi with Russian president Vladimir Putin at the SCO summit in Samarkand

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